

In the “City of Joy”

As early as 1949, the Government of West Bengal toyed with the idea of an underground transport system in Kolkata. A team of French specialists explored the feasibility of such a system, recommending certain sections. However, there was no further movement in the project. Efforts to expand roads did not yield favourable results and the situation continued to worsen.

In 1969, the Metropolitan Transport Team of the Planning Commission recommended a rapid transport system and by 1971, a plan was in place to build three lines – Dumdum–Tollygunge, Bidhannagar–Ramrajatala, and Dakshineswar–Thakurpukur. The highest priority was given to the Dumdum–Tollygunge section and construction began in 1972. By 1984, the stretch between Esplanade and Bhowanipur was opened for service and the entire north–south line became operational by 1995. In recent years, the line was extended to Noapara on one side and New Garia on the other.

The construction of the second line, or the east–west metro corridor, between Salt Lake Sector V and Howrah Maidan, started in 2009. Although implemented by the Kolkata Metro Rail Corporation (KMRC), the project will be operated by the Metro Railway, Kolkata, the only metro under the Indian Railways. Still under construction, the east–west line is unique because its section between Lal Dighi and the Howrah station would pass under the Hooghly River, making it the first underwater metro in India. Several other lines have been sanctioned as well, including Joka–Esplanade, Noapara–Barasat, and Baranagar–Barrackpore. There are also plans to provide connectivity between the main city and suburbs.

The capital

Delhi followed Kolkata’s lead to implement the Mass Rapid Transport System (MRTS) across the city with the formation of the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) in 1995, which was jointly owned by the Central Government and Government of the National Capital Territory of Delhi. The first metro stretch opened in 2002 between Shahdara and Tis Hazari. The network has diversified considerably over the years, not just within the city, but even to surrounding areas, such as Ghaziabad, Noida,